

Footnote¹

From “is this even true?” to “here’s what I can do about it.”

Live now: footnote.alessandrarye.com

¹ Civic grounding for public claims: sources, transparency, and a real local next step.

Alee • Metana Full Stack Capstone • 4-week MVP

The gap between seeing and doing

A resident sees a post: *“the new levy money is going to administrator raises.”*

Today she has three dead ends. She can't easily check it. If she checks it, she gets a verdict with no reasoning. And nothing tells her what to actually do next, so she shares it, or shrugs.

Early signal: an attorney, a librarian, and a student, interviewed separately, each described this exact gap, and all three responded positively to Footnote.

1

Verification tools stop at the verdict

Fact-checks and trust ratings end with “true-ish.” Then nothing.

2

Civic software is sold to governments

The municipality is the customer; the resident is the audience.

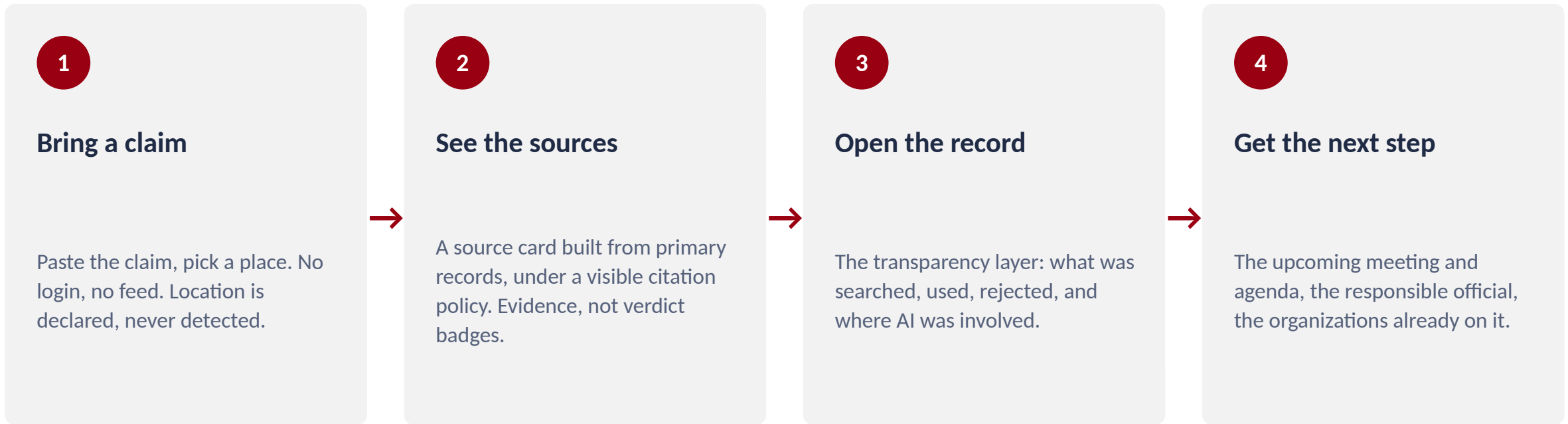
3

Community platforms have neither

Where claims actually spread, there's no verification and no path to action.

Nobody connects *“I saw this claim”* to **“here is what I can do about it.”**

The solution: one path, four steps



Then the session ends and evaporates. No profiles, no tracking, no engagement optimization, no ads. The constraints are the product.

The data: where it comes from, why it can be trusted

Primary sources only

- County, city, and school district official sites
- Agenda portals: BoardDocs, Legistar / CivicClerk
- Board of Elections: ballot & levy language
- Ohio Revised Code & codified ordinances
- OpenStates API for state legislators
- **Nothing below the primary-record tier enters the civic layer**

Provenance on every entry

- Each datum carries: source link · date verified · tier
- Staleness is displayed, never hidden (“verified 60 days ago”)
- Data lives in version-controlled files; the git history is the audit log
- Report-an-error path closes the loop
- **Same standard the tool applies to claims, applied to itself**

The promise is not “the data is true.” It’s “you can always see where it came from and when it was checked.”

Competitors: three camps, one empty seam

Media trust tools

Ground News • NewsGuard • AI verification APIs
(Factiveverse, ClaimBuster)

Stop at the verdict.

Gov-side civic platforms

CivicPlus • OpenGov • Granicus

Sold to governments; the citizen isn't the customer. Roadmaps bet on personalization.

Community platforms

Nextdoor • Facebook groups • local forums

Own the attention where claims spread. No verification, no path to action.

On the radar • Google: substitutes for the verification half (Search, AI Overviews). Ran a Civic Information API for local officials data and shut it down in 2025. The moat, demonstrated.

OCLC: budget-adjacent in the library market, not functional. Standing rule: Footnote ingests no library-vendor data, only government primary records.

Footnote occupies the connection: verification → local action. The curated local layer and transparency machinery are the moat; their maintenance cost is why it holds.

Tech stack

FE

Frontend

React (Vite) • responsive web app, phone and desktop • every screen reachable by URL

API

Backend

Node.js + Express REST API • claim pipeline as composable stages (classify → source → policy → invite)

DB

Data

PostgreSQL for sessions & records • civic locality package as version-controlled YAML with per-entry provenance

AI

Model layer

Claude API for claim classification & policy-constrained summarization • behind an adapter, swappable • every model call logged to the transparency record

OPS

Infra & process

AWS EC2 + nginx + pm2, HTTPS via Let's Encrypt • GitHub Actions CI • Issues + Projects board, branch protection, decisions log

Scope fence and the four weeks

MoSCoW

Must: one locality (Delaware County area), one complete path: claim in, source card, transparency record, civic invitation out. Deployed.

Should: second claim type • citation-policy toggle

Could: polish states • locality “not yet covered” preview

Won't (by design): accounts & profiles • feeds or posts • second civic slice • topic packages • curation console • live ingestion at scale

Wk 1

Walking skeleton: one hardcoded claim through the whole path, deployed, ugly.

Wk 2

Real claim handling + classification slice. Fallback trigger lives here.

Wk 3

Civic invitation layer with real local data; second claim type if on pace.

Wk 4

Hardening, error states, polish, demo prep, built-in buffer.

Beyond the capstone: the pattern generalizes

1 Topic packages The same provenance engine aimed at issues residents feel but don't research: regional data-center siting, water & power agreements, documented public-accountability records. Primary documents only; cite, never characterize.

2 Librarian curation console Libraries as the local editorial layer, maintaining locality data through the same source-and-date schema, extending library confidentiality ethics into software.

3 Community source submission People can hand Footnote evidence; nobody can hand it an opinion. Reviewed pipeline, no posts, no identities, no audience.

Sustainability: free for citizens, always · institutional licensing (libraries, schools) · engine as an API · grants bridge · no ads, no engagement monetization, ever.

Footnote¹

You pick a place. It shows you the records, shows its work, and hands you the next step. Then it forgets you.

Live demo: <https://footnote.alessandrarye.com> · repo + decisions log + build-log posts linked in the README

¹ Questions welcome, especially the hard ones. The transparency record applies to me too.